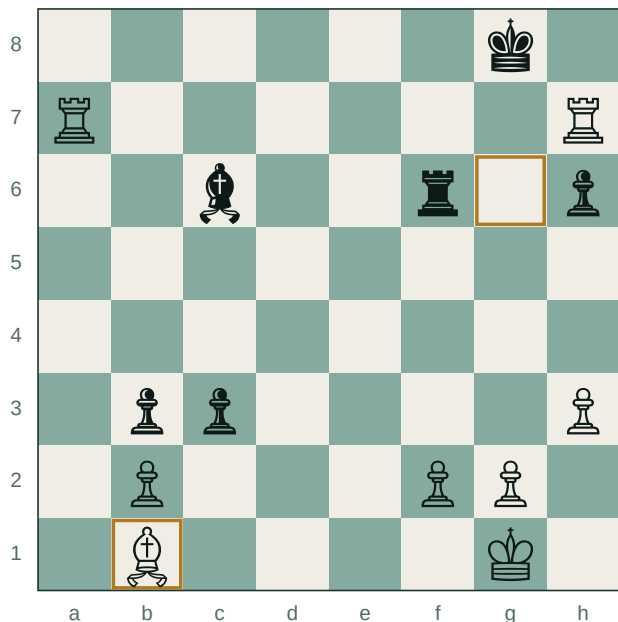


Trapping a piece: Black, move 39

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 39.Bb1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...c2 40. Bxc2 bxc2 41. Ra1 Kxh7

39...c2 The pawn moves from c3 to c2. Recorded reply: **40.Bxc2**.

40...bxc2 The pawn captures the bishop on c2. Recorded reply: **41.Ra1**.

41...Kxh7 The king captures the rook on h7.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 10 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +7. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +7: the balance goes from -6 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on b1. Check for tactical protection.